

Organization Behaviour (MIM201A) — Previous Year Question Paper

CS/BBA(C)/EVEN/SEM-2/2500004/2024-2025/I187 | Full Marks: 70 | Time: 3 Hours — Model Answers

Group-A: Very Short Answer Type (1 × 10 = 10)

(i) Hofstede's cultural dimensions theory identifies dimensions such as power distance, individualism vs. collectivism, and _____.

Answer: masculinity vs. femininity (also: uncertainty avoidance, long-term vs. short-term orientation)

(ii) _____ emphasized designing and managing organization on an impersonal, rational basis through such elements as clearly defined authority and responsibility, formal record keeping and uniform application of standard rule.

Answer: Bureaucracy (Max Weber's Bureaucratic Theory)

(iii) The personality type of people who believe that they are the masters of their destiny is _____.

Answer: Internal locus of control (Internals)

(iv) A group that is relatively permanent and is specified in the organizational structure is called _____.

Answer: Formal group

(v) Employees engaged in organizational politics often use tactics such as _____ to gain power and influence within the organization.

Answer: networking, coalition building, impression management, controlling information

(vi) Managing _____ teams requires understanding and leveraging cultural differences for effective collaboration.

Answer: Cross-cultural (multicultural/virtual global) teams

(vii) The first set of Hawthorne experiments dealing with lighting, the main conclusion was that _____.

Answer: Changes in physical working conditions (like lighting) had little effect on productivity — psychological and social factors, like being observed and feeling important, mattered more.

(viii) _____ determines the behaviour of individuals and workgroups and affects the overall performance of the organisation.

Answer: Organizational culture

(ix) In group development, a leader unites the team with motivation. This stage is called _____.

Answer: Norming (some texts call it Performing if motivation accompanies unity, but the standard Tuckman stage where the team unites is "Norming")

(x) Organizational politics can lead to _____ among employees and can undermine trust and collaboration within teams.

Answer: conflict, stress, and distrust

(xi) Why is cultural sensitivity important for effective cross-cultural communication in international business?

Answer: Cultural sensitivity helps people understand and respect different values, communication styles, and customs, reducing misunderstandings and building trust, which makes cross-cultural communication in international business more effective and avoids costly cultural mistakes.

(xii) As per which approach, factors like Technology, Environment and Organization size should be considered for designing more effective organizational structure?

Answer: Contingency Approach (to organizational design)

Group-B: Short Answer Type (5 × 3 = 15)

Q2. Describe Contingency Approach.

5 Marks

Question: Describe Contingency Approach.

The Contingency Approach states that there is no single "best" way to manage or organize a company — the right management style, structure, or strategy depends on the specific situation a manager faces. It is a reaction against the "one-size-fits-all" classical approach.

Key situational factors (contingency variables) that influence the right approach include:

- **Environment:** Whether the external environment is stable or rapidly changing.
- **Technology:** Routine technology favors rigid structures; complex technology needs flexible ones.
- **Organization size:** Large organizations need more formal rules than small ones.
- **People involved:** Employees' skills, values, and expectations.

For example, a mechanistic (rigid, rule-based) structure works well in a stable environment, while an organic (flexible, adaptive) structure suits a fast-changing environment. The contingency approach encourages managers to diagnose their unique situation before choosing leadership style, organizational design, or motivational technique.

Q3. Explain the difference between leaders and managers.

5 Marks

Question: Explain the difference between leaders and managers.

Although the terms are often used interchangeably, leadership and management are different concepts:

Basis	Manager	Leader
Focus	Planning, organizing, controlling resources	Inspiring and guiding people toward a vision
Source of power	Formal authority/position	Personal influence and trust
Approach	Maintains order and stability	Drives change and innovation
Relationship with people	Directs subordinates	Motivates and empowers followers

Goal orientation	Achieves organizational goals efficiently	Creates and communicates a vision for the future
------------------	---	--

In short, managers do things right (efficiency), while leaders do the right things (effectiveness and direction). A good manager is not always a leader, and a good leader does not always hold managerial authority, though the most effective people in an organization combine both qualities.

Q4. State general differences between work groups and work teams.

5 Marks

Question: State general differences between work groups and work teams.

Basis	Work Group	Work Team
Goal	Members share information and make decisions to help each do their own job better	Members work toward a common, collective goal
Synergy	Neutral or even negative synergy	Positive synergy — output greater than sum of inputs
Accountability	Individual accountability	Individual and mutual (joint) accountability
Skills	Random and varied skills	Complementary skills
Leadership	Strong, single leader	Shared/rotating leadership roles

In short, a group is a collection of individuals working somewhat independently, while a team is a tightly coordinated unit working interdependently toward one shared objective.

Q5. Define authority and how is it different from power.

5 Marks

Question: Define authority and how is it different from power.

Authority is the formal, legitimate right granted to a person by virtue of their position in the organizational hierarchy to give orders, make decisions, and direct subordinates to act in a certain way. It flows downward through the formal chain of command and is recognized officially by the organization.

Power, on the other hand, is the broader capacity or ability of a person to influence the behaviour of others so that they act according to one's wishes — regardless of formal position.

Key differences:

- Authority is always formal/legitimate; power can be formal or informal.

- Authority comes with the position (e.g., a manager's title); power can come from expertise, charisma, control of resources, or information, even without holding a position.
- Authority is a subset of power — every person with authority has power, but a person can have power without having formal authority (e.g., an informal leader in a team).

Q6. Write in brief about McGregor's Theory X and Theory Y.

5 Marks

Question: Write in brief about McGregor's Theory X and Theory Y.

Douglas McGregor proposed two contrasting sets of assumptions managers hold about employee motivation:

Theory X (negative view): Assumes employees inherently dislike work, are lazy, avoid responsibility, and must be closely supervised, directed, and controlled — often through threats and strict rules — to achieve organizational goals.

Theory Y (positive view): Assumes employees can enjoy work, are self-motivated, capable of self-direction, willingly accept responsibility, and can exercise creativity if given the right environment and trust.

Managers who believe in Theory X tend to adopt an authoritarian, controlling management style, whereas Theory Y managers adopt a participative, empowering style that focuses on building trust and offering autonomy. McGregor argued that Theory Y assumptions generally lead to higher motivation and better long-term performance.

Group-C: Long Answer Type (15 × 3 = 45)**Q7. Group cohesiveness — causes and consequences****15 Marks**

Question: What do you mean by group cohesiveness? Discuss in detail the causes and consequences of group cohesiveness in an organization.

Meaning: Group cohesiveness refers to the degree to which members of a group are attracted to one another, feel a sense of belonging, and are motivated to stay in and contribute to the group. A highly cohesive group acts and feels like a unified whole, with members supporting each other and sharing common goals.

Causes (factors that increase cohesiveness):

- **Similarity of members:** Shared attitudes, values, and backgrounds increase mutual liking.
- **Small group size:** Smaller groups allow more interaction and stronger bonds than large ones.
- **Proximity/frequent interaction:** Members who work close together or interact often build stronger relationships.
- **Common goals and shared success:** Working toward and achieving a shared objective unites members.
- **External threat or competition:** Facing a common rival or challenge from outside often pulls a group closer together.
- **Group status and exclusivity:** Being part of a prestigious or selective group increases members' desire to belong.
- **Time spent together:** Longer association allows trust to build.

Consequences of group cohesiveness:*Positive consequences:*

- Higher member satisfaction and lower turnover/absenteeism.
- Better communication and cooperation among members.
- Increased productivity, *provided* the group's goals align with organizational goals.
- Greater willingness to support and help each other, raising morale.

Negative consequences:

- **Groupthink:** Excessive cohesiveness can suppress independent or critical thinking, leading to poor decisions.
- If group goals conflict with organizational goals, high cohesiveness can actually *reduce* overall productivity (e.g., a cohesive group restricting output together).
- Resistance to new members or outside ideas, leading to insularity.

Conclusion: Cohesiveness is generally beneficial, but managers must ensure that the group's goals are aligned with the organization's goals, otherwise a tightly-knit group can work efficiently in a direction that hurts the organization.

Q8. Techniques for managing stress, individually and at the workplace

15 Marks

Question: Discuss the various techniques for managing strength both individually and at the workplace.

(Note: this question is generally about managing "stress" — read as "strength/stress management techniques" individually and organizationally.)

Stress arises when job demands exceed an individual's ability to cope. It can be managed at two levels:

A. Individual-level techniques:

- **Time management:** Prioritizing tasks, setting realistic deadlines, and avoiding procrastination reduces pressure.
- **Physical exercise:** Regular exercise (walking, yoga, sports) releases tension and improves mood and energy.
- **Relaxation techniques:** Meditation, deep breathing, and mindfulness lower physiological arousal caused by stress.
- **Social support network:** Talking to friends, family, or colleagues helps release frustration and gain perspective.
- **Maintaining work-life balance:** Setting boundaries between work and personal life prevents burnout.
- **Cognitive restructuring:** Changing how one interprets stressful situations (viewing them as challenges rather than threats).

B. Organizational-level techniques:

- **Improved selection and placement:** Matching the right person to the right job to avoid role mismatch stress.
- **Goal setting:** Setting clear, specific, and achievable goals reduces ambiguity-related stress.

- **Redesigning jobs:** Giving employees more autonomy, variety, and meaningful tasks reduces monotony-related stress.
- **Improved organizational communication:** Keeping employees informed reduces uncertainty and role ambiguity.
- **Employee wellness/assistance programs:** Offering counseling, health screenings, and stress-management workshops.
- **Flexible work arrangements:** Options like flexible hours or remote work help employees manage personal and professional demands.

Conclusion: Effective stress management requires a combination of personal coping strategies and supportive organizational policies, since stress originates from both individual and work-environment factors.

Q9. Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Theory and its implications for international management

15 Marks

Question: Explain Hofstede's cultural dimensions theory and discuss its implications for international management practices. Provide examples of how these dimensions impact organizational behavior.

Geert Hofstede studied employees across many countries and identified dimensions along which national cultures differ. These help managers understand how culture shapes workplace behaviour. The key dimensions are:

1. **Power Distance:** The degree to which less powerful members of a society accept unequal power distribution. *High power distance* (e.g., India, Malaysia) — employees expect clear hierarchy and respect authority. *Low power distance* (e.g., Denmark, Sweden) — employees expect participative, egalitarian relationships with managers.
2. **Individualism vs. Collectivism:** Individualist cultures (e.g., USA, UK) value personal achievement and independence; collectivist cultures (e.g., China, Japan) value group loyalty and harmony.
3. **Masculinity vs. Femininity:** Masculine cultures (e.g., Japan) emphasize competitiveness, achievement, and material success; feminine cultures (e.g., Netherlands, Norway) emphasize cooperation, quality of life, and caring for others.
4. **Uncertainty Avoidance:** The degree to which people feel uncomfortable with ambiguity and unstructured situations. High uncertainty-avoidance cultures (e.g., Greece, Japan) prefer strict rules and structure; low ones (e.g., Singapore) are more comfortable with ambiguity and change.

5. **Long-term vs. Short-term Orientation:** Long-term oriented cultures (e.g., China) value persistence, thrift, and future rewards; short-term oriented cultures value quick results and tradition.

Implications for international management:

- **Leadership style:** In high power-distance cultures, directive leadership is more accepted; in low power-distance cultures, participative leadership works better.
- **Team design:** In collectivist cultures, team-based rewards and group harmony work better than individual competition, which suits individualist cultures.
- **HR policies:** Performance appraisal and reward systems need to be adapted — individual bonuses may motivate in the US but cause discomfort in collectivist Japan.
- **Communication style:** In high uncertainty-avoidance cultures, detailed contracts and clear instructions are preferred over open-ended, flexible arrangements.
- **Negotiation and decision making:** Long-term oriented cultures may favor patient, relationship-based negotiation, while short-term oriented cultures may seek quick deals.

Conclusion: Hofstede's framework helps international managers avoid a "one-size-fits-all" approach, tailoring leadership, motivation, and HR practices to the cultural context of each country in which they operate.

Q10. Need for knowledge of OB to a practicing manager

15 Marks

Question: Highlight the need for knowledge of OB to practicing manager.

Organizational Behaviour (OB) is the systematic study of how individuals and groups behave within organizations. Knowledge of OB is essential to a practicing manager for the following reasons:

- **Understanding employee behaviour:** OB helps managers understand why employees act, think, and feel the way they do, enabling better prediction and management of their actions.
- **Improving motivation:** Knowledge of motivation theories (Maslow, Herzberg, McGregor, etc.) helps managers design reward systems and job conditions that boost employee performance.
- **Effective leadership:** OB equips managers with leadership styles and skills to influence and guide teams toward organizational goals.
- **Better communication:** Understanding interpersonal and group dynamics improves communication, reducing misunderstandings and conflicts.
- **Conflict management:** OB provides tools to identify the sources of conflict and resolve them constructively, maintaining a healthy work environment.

- **Managing change:** OB knowledge helps managers anticipate resistance to change and implement change management strategies effectively.
- **Improving group/team performance:** Insight into group dynamics, cohesiveness, and team-building helps managers create high-performing teams.
- **Enhancing job satisfaction and reducing turnover:** Understanding employee attitudes helps design jobs and policies that increase satisfaction and retention.
- **Handling diversity and culture:** In today's globalized workplace, OB helps managers manage cross-cultural and diverse teams effectively.
- **Organizational effectiveness:** Ultimately, applying OB principles helps achieve higher productivity, employee well-being, and overall organizational success.

Conclusion: Since management is fundamentally about getting work done through people, a sound understanding of OB is not optional but essential for any manager who wants to lead effectively, build strong teams, and achieve sustainable organizational performance.

Q11. Interpersonal vs. structural resources of power; political behaviour and its causes

15 Marks

Question: Compare and contrast interpersonal and structural resources of power in organisations. Define political behaviour. What are some of the factors that can contribute to organisational politics?

Interpersonal sources of power arise from a person's individual characteristics and relationships, regardless of their formal position. French and Raven identified five bases of power, most of which are interpersonal:

- **Reward power:** Ability to give rewards (raises, promotions, praise).
- **Coercive power:** Ability to punish or threaten negative consequences.
- **Legitimate power:** Power derived from one's formal position/authority.
- **Expert power:** Power based on special skills, knowledge, or expertise.
- **Referent power:** Power based on personal charisma, likability, or admiration others have for the person.

Structural sources of power arise from a person's position within the organization's structure and their access to key resources, regardless of their personal traits:

- **Resources:** Control over budgets, staff, equipment, or information gives power.
- **Decision-making authority:** Being part of key decisions increases influence.
- **Information:** Access to and control of important information makes a person indispensable.

- **Network centrality:** Occupying a central position in communication or social networks increases influence.

Comparison: Interpersonal power is tied to the person (their traits, expertise, charisma) and travels with them even if they change jobs, whereas structural power is tied to the position/role and is lost once the person leaves that role.

Political behaviour: Political behaviour refers to activities that are not officially sanctioned by the organization, undertaken by individuals or groups to acquire, develop, or use power and other resources to obtain their preferred outcomes in situations of uncertainty or disagreement.

Factors contributing to organizational politics:

- **Scarcity of resources:** When resources (budget, promotions, recognition) are limited, competition leads to political behaviour.
- **Ambiguous goals and rules:** Unclear policies or performance criteria create room for manipulation and self-interest.
- **Complex/decentralized decision-making:** The more people involved in decisions, the more opportunity for coalition-building and politicking.
- **High stakes/uncertainty:** Important decisions with unclear outcomes (e.g., restructuring, promotions) encourage political maneuvering.
- **Performance evaluation systems:** Subjective or poorly defined appraisal systems can be more easily influenced through politics.
- **Individual personality traits:** Employees high in need for power, Machiavellianism, or self-monitoring are more likely to engage in political behaviour.
- **Organizational culture:** A culture that tolerates or rewards political tactics encourages further political behaviour.

Conclusion: While power can stem from both personal qualities and structural position, organizational politics emerges when resources are scarce and rules are ambiguous, making it important for managers to create transparent systems to minimize its negative effects.